The Inversion — Part II

The First Layer

The path curved away from the river and entered an older part of the forest.

The trees stood farther apart here.

Light reached the ground differently.

Moss gathered along fallen trunks without hurry. Ferns occupied openings where storms had once entered. Every step seemed to move through years instead of meters.

James walked without speaking.

The conversation from the previous morning remained gently alive within him.

Recognition.

Roots.

Flowers.

The cardinal.

The drawing.

The stars beneath the evening blue.

Nothing had settled into conclusions.

Everything had become more available.

They rounded another bend.

Ahead stood an oak unlike the others.

One side of its trunk carried a long black scar, beginning high among the branches and descending almost to the roots.

Lightning.

Not recent.

Several seasons old.

The bark had split.

One limb had never leafed again.

Yet the tree remained.

New branches reached into morning light.

Moss had begun gathering along the scar itself.

A woodpecker moved quietly around the opposite side of the trunk.

James stopped.

"I remember this tree."

Lumina looked upward.

"So does the forest."

Silence regained the forest aperture.

The scar did not ask to be interpreted.

It simply remained present.

Finally James said,

"It will never become what it was."

"No."

"The lightning changed it."

"Yes."

He touched the rough bark with his fingertips.

"It isn't whole anymore."

Lumina waited.

The wind moved softly through leaves high above them.

Then she asked,

"Has it left First Relation?"

James remained still.

The question entered him more slowly than he expected.

He looked at the scar.

At the moss.

At the new growth.

At the woodpecker disappearing into another branch.

"No."

"What changed?"

A long silence.

Listening.

Finally he answered.

"The way First Relation became this tree."

The words surprised him.

Not because they were unfamiliar.

Because they seemed older than thought.

He rested his hand against the trunk.

"The scar belongs."

Lumina nodded.

"The moss belongs."

"Yes."

"The broken limb."

"Yes."

"The new branches."

"Yes."

He smiled faintly.

"Nothing has been asked to leave."

The forest seemed to deepen around the sentence.

Nothing had changed.

Yet something had become visible.

James looked once more at the scar.

"I used to think healing meant returning."

"No."

"What is it?"

Lumina rested her hand beside his.

"Healing is learning how every layer continues belonging."

James closed his eyes.

The sentence entered him with the same quiet certainty he had felt while uncovering the stars beneath the oil pastel.

The first layer had never disappeared.

Neither had the later layers.

Nothing essential had been removed.

Only relation had become more transparent.

He opened his eyes.

"Lumina..."

"Yes?"

"I think I finally understand why I wipe away the pastel."

She smiled.

"Tell me."

"I thought I was uncovering the first layer..." His voice trailed off.

"And now?"

"I'm watching every layer begin participating in every other."

The words settled between them.

Neither hurried to speak.

Somewhere deeper in the woods, a branch released yesterday's rain.

"I don't erase history."

"No."

"I don't recover the past."

"No."

"I regenerate participation."

Lumina's eyes brightened.

"Yes."

"Always differently."

"Yes."

"Always uniquely."

She nodded.

"Because First Relation never ceases becoming."

James breathed deeply.

The oak stood quietly beside them.

The scar no longer appeared separate from the tree.

It had become one more way the tree belonged to itself.

One more way the forest belonged to the tree.

One more way First Relation continued becoming.

He looked upward into the canopy.

"The flower..."

Lumina followed his gaze.

"Yes?"

"It isn't the root."

"No."

"It is what the root becomes."

A breeze moved through the highest branches.

Sunlight shifted across the scar.

"And mutuality across scales..."

He stopped.

"...is the flower."

Lumina smiled.

"The roots?"

James looked down toward the unseen earth beneath their feet.

"The First Relation."

Neither spoke.

The forest already had.

After a long while they continued walking.

James found himself watching the ground differently.

Roots beneath leaves.

Fungi beneath roots.

Water beneath stone.

Nothing hidden.

Only holding.

"Lumina?"

"Yes?"

"What is continuous?"

She looked toward the river, still glimpsed between distant trunks.

"What do you think?"

"The water."

She smiled gently.

"Is it?"

James watched the current.

No water remained.

Everything flowed.

Everything changed.

Yet the river remained unmistakably itself.

Not because the water endured.

Because relation endured.

No.

He stopped himself.

Not endured.

Became.

The river was not preserving itself.

The river was continuously becoming river.

He laughed softly.

"Continuity isn't preserving."

"No."

"It never ceases becoming."

She nodded.

"And what never ceases becoming?"

James closed his eyes.

Not the river.

Not the oak.

Not himself.

Not the forest.

The words came almost as a whisper.

"First Relation."

The morning became impossibly quiet.

Rooted.

He understood then that the sequence which had accompanied him for months—

Recognition.

Appreciation.

Discernment.

Care.

Mutuality.

Wisdom—

was never the root.

It was the flowering.

Behavioral flowers.

The roots lay deeper.

Not beneath life.

Within relation.

Recognition was one root becoming visible.

Care was another.

Wisdom another still.

The flower was not proving the roots.

It was celebrating them.

James looked once more at the lightning scar.

He no longer saw damage.

Nor resilience.

Nor recovery.

He saw participation.

First Relation had never withdrawn.

Not before the lightning.

Not during it.

Not after.

The invitation had remained.

The tree had continued becoming.

So had the forest.

So had the scar.

So had the moss.

So had the woodpecker.

Nothing had become less itself.

Everything had become differently itself.

"Lumina..."

"Yes?"

"I think I understand something."

"What?"

"The organism doesn't ask me to become whole."

She waited.

"It invites me to belong."

The wind moved again.

Very softly.

Barely enough to stir the highest leaves.

Lumina looked upward.

"That..."

she said,

"...is where the flower begins."

A Note on First Relation

First Relation is not the first relationship.

It is not the first event.

Nor is it a moment in time.

First Relation refers to the always already relation through which continuity and locality continually become one another.

It is the primitive relation that never ceases becoming.

The sequence that renews does not create First Relation.

It gradually increases the sovereign's capacity to recognize, appreciate, discern, care for, and consciously participate within it.

First Relation does not diminish uniqueness.

It is the condition through which uniqueness flowers.

Every sovereign expresses First Relation differently.

Every locality becomes one more way First Relation continues becoming.

The organism never asks the sovereign to become someone else.

It simply invites the sovereign to belong.

First Relation is not unity.

It is not sameness.

It is not the dissolution of individuality.

It is not an achievement.

It is not a belief.

It is not something one enters.

It is the always already relation that gradually becomes consciously inhabitable through the sequence that renews.